The Ideal Piano Learning App: Deep Research Report (v2)

For Jeremy Howe · second, deeper pass completed Oct 25, 2026 (CDT). Focus areas: (a) finger exercises and technique, (b) chords and scales, (c) common musical patterns.

> **Data rules.** The App Store figures (rating, rating count, price, last update) were pulled live on **Oct 25, 2026** from Apple's iTunes Search/Lookup API (US storefront). Google Play figures were read from the live Play listing pages that same day. The review-theme counts come from **2,411 actual App Store reviews** downloaded via Apple's customer-review RSS feed for 17 apps. Anything I could not confirm is marked **unknown**. The "MIDI / Mic in listing" columns only mean the app's own description mentions that input. They are not a test of how well it works.

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0. What changed from v1

- **Verified app count went from about 15 to 90 iOS apps with live data, plus 13 Google Play listings and 16 web, desktop, or open-source tools, for 119 entries.** v1 had 58 entries with mostly "Unk" ratings.
- I added 2,411 real App Store reviews with complaint-theme counts and quotes for 17 apps.
- I added Piano World forum threads, a Hacker News "Piano Trainer" thread (203 points, 58 comments), more Reddit threads, and YouTube and blog app roundups.
- **Pedagogy is now cited from the source:** Hanon-Faber (Hal Leonard), the Fundamentals of Piano Practice critique of Hanon, the Pianist magazine Hanon critique, the Robert Pace Multi-Key method, A Dozen a Day, Alfred vs. Faber adult courses, Bill Hilton, the Open Studio jazz pathway, and Pianote.
- **Research added:** Jabusch MIDI scale-evenness benchmarks, adult-learner motivation and dropout studies, the FSRS spaced-repetition benchmark, BLE-MIDI latency measurements, and Verovio's Swift package.
- **New direct competitors discovered:** Playy Piano, Chordwise ("Piano chords and scales MIDI"), The Ultimate Piano (web), PianoSkillBoost, Piano Trainer (open source), Chord Nebula, The Hanon Method app, and Artie (AI).
- **Corrections from v1:**
- Skoove: 4.58★ / 22,307 on the App Store, 4.5★ / 12.4K reviews on Google Play.
- Playground: 4.77★ / 5,014 on iOS but **3.4★ / 175 on Google Play**.
- Piano Marvel: 4.67★ / 5,519 on iOS.
- Pianote price: $30/mo or $279/yr per pianote.com (via Practis).
- "Piano Maestro" by JoyTunes no longer appears in search. The "Piano Music Maestro" listing is a different app.
- Chordana Play is 2.74★ / 69. Roland Piano App is 2.32★ / 235.

1. Sources opened in this pass

Data at scale - iTunes Search API, run with 43 query terms (piano lessons, learn piano, piano chords, piano scales, hanon, sight reading, music theory, ear training, piano technique, piano teacher, piano practice, chord progressions, jazz piano, keyboard lessons, piano midi, note reading, piano exercises, plus 25 brand-name queries). That gave 1,857 unique apps, filtered to piano-relevant teaching apps. - The iTunes Lookup API, for the apps added by hand. - App Store customer-review RSS: up to 3 pages × 50 reviews for each of 17 apps. - Google Play listing pages for 13 apps.

Comparison articles and videos - Preply: https://preply.com/en/blog/best-piano-learning-apps/ - Practis 2026 retest: https://pract.is/blog/best-piano-learning-apps-adults-2026 - Practis Pianote review: https://pract.is/blog/pianote-review-2026 - Practis, Alfred vs. Faber: https://pract.is/blog/alfred-vs-faber-adult-piano - Piano Nova: https://piano-nova.com/vs/flowkey-vs-simply-piano - AppTierList: https://apptierlist.com/best/piano-learning/ - ItalianPiano critique: https://www.italianpiano.com/piano/review-of-simply-piano-app-for-learning-to-play-the-piano/ - Deviant Noise, Melodics review: https://deviantnoise.net/education/piano/melodics-review/ - Digital Trends: https://www.digitaltrends.com/phones/best-piano-learning-apps/ - Jeremy See, one month on apps:

https://www.jeremysee.info/post/i-learned-piano-using-music-apps-for-a-month-here-s-what-actually-works - YouTube roundups (titles and summaries only; transcripts not read): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8oONUtDGPCo and https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eLdCd7zl-NI

Communities - r/piano: https://www.reddit.com/r/piano/comments/1qbxj96/ , https://www.reddit.com/r/piano/comments/1rn130j/ , https://www.reddit.com/r/piano/comments/1h8o9qq/ , https://www.reddit.com/r/piano/comments/1dub8sk/ - r/pianolearning: https://www.reddit.com/r/pianolearning/comments/1s8wsvy/ , https://www.reddit.com/r/pianolearning/comments/1r6eibr/ , https://www.reddit.com/r/pianolearning/comments/11ej031/ - r/musictheory: https://www.reddit.com/r/musictheory/comments/1j068d4/ - r/Melodics: https://www.reddit.com/r/Melodics/comments/15fnd01/ - Piano World: https://forum.pianoworld.com/ubbthreads.php/topics/3247993/ , /3191725/ , /2614446/1.html , /3226829/ - Hacker News: https://news.ycombinator.com/item?id=44467838 (Piano Trainer), https://news.ycombinator.com/item?id=42416258 (Chord Nebula), https://news.ycombinator.com/item?id=41144826 (Hanon Pro) - Note: Reddit's JSON API blocked direct scripted access from my machine, so I read Reddit threads through search snapshots instead.

Pedagogy - Hanon-Faber preface: https://www.halleonard.com/bin/MiscEducationalKeyboardHanonfaber.pdf - Fundamentals of Piano Practice, problems with Hanon: https://www.pianofundamentals.com/book/en/1.III.7.8 - Pianist magazine on Hanon: https://www.pianistmagazine.com/blogs/this-is-why-hanon-exercises-are-a-waste-of-time-and-possibly-dangerous/ - The Hanon Debate: https://practisingthepiano.com/the-hanon-debate/ - Pace Multi-Key: https://pacepiano-leerobertsmusic.com/pages/robert-pace_why-multi-key and https://leerobertsmusic.com/pdfs/Transposing.pdf - A Dozen a Day: https://www.halleonard.com/product/413366/a-dozen-a-day-book-1 and https://archive.org/details/dozendaytechnica00burn - Faber Adult: https://pianoadventures.com/product/adult-piano-adventures-all-in-one-course-book-1/ - Bill Hilton: https://billspianopages.com/how-to-really - Open Studio: https://www.openstudiojazz.com/courses/piano-pathway-introductory-jazz-piano/ - Pianist magazine, ballad style: https://www.pianistmagazine.com/blogs/how-to-play-ballad-style-piano/ - MTAC technique toolbox: https://www.mtac.org/wp-content/uploads/2013/05/A-Teaching-Toolbox-for-Optimal-Technique-and-Practice-at-the-Piano.pdf

Research - Interleaving: https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8476370/ - Spacing in piano: https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371%2Fjournal.pone.0182986 - Sleep consolidation: https://doi.org/10.1177/002242940605400203 and https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/002242940605400308 - Jabusch scale timing: https://www.immm.hmtm-hannover.de/en/research/previous-research-projects/timing-precision-displayed-by-pianists/ , https://doi.org/10.1002/mds.10671 , https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00134/full - Adult learners: https://doi.org/10.1177/002242940605400202 , https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/0305735610376262 , https://digitalcommons.unl.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1002&context=musicfacpub , https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02868/full - FSRS: https://expertium.github.io/Benchmark.html and https://github.com/open-spaced-repetition/srs-benchmark

Technology - Apple QA1831, BLE MIDI: https://developer.apple.com/library/archive/qa/qa1831/_index.html - BLE MIDI latency: https://music.stackexchange.com/questions/48767/bluetooth-le-midi-latency and https://www.nime.org/proceedings/2019/nime2019_paper006.pdf - Verovio Swift: https://book.verovio.org/installing-or-building-from-sources/swift-and-objective-c.html - Basic Pitch: https://github.com/spotify/basic-pitch , https://github.com/zhangyufei49/BasicPitchSwift , https://github.com/spotify/basic-pitch/issues/108 - Mobile-AMT: https://eurasip.org/Proceedings/Eusipco/Eusipco2024/pdfs/0000036.pdf - Hanon Pro: https://furnacecreek.org/hanon/ - Playy: https://playy.app/ - The Ultimate Piano: https://the-ultimate-piano.com/

Not reached: YouTube transcripts, Pianostreet threads, the paywalled full texts of the journal papers (I used abstracts), and Czerny or Suzuki at the source (I used general knowledge there).

2. Market at a glance (verified)

- **Popularity is extremely concentrated.**
- Simply Piano has **859,201** iOS ratings and **994K** Google Play reviews with **50M+** installs. That is nearly 2× the next app (MWM, 442,765).
- On iOS: MWM "Piano: Keyboard Lessons & Game" 442,765, flowkey 65,849, Yousician Piano 22,807, Skoove 22,307, Hello Piano 12,768, Piano Marvel 5,519, Playground 5,014, Musora 2,985, Artie (new AI app) 2,797.
- **Technique, chord, and scale specialists are tiny.**

- Piano Companion: 1,328 iOS ratings. Its Android listing ("Piano Chords, Scales Companion", package com.binitex.pianochords; I assume it is the same product but did not confirm the developer match): 23.4K reviews and 1M+ installs.
- Tenuto: 667. Hanon Pro: **7**. The Hanon Method: 12. Chordwise: 1 on iOS, 1K+ installs on Android.
- Piano Chords and Scales: 9,285 on iOS, the largest reference-style app.
- **There's no mass-market winner in your focus areas.** That's the opportunity.
- **Hardware-maker apps are poorly rated:** Roland Piano App 2.32★ (235), Chordana Play 2.74★ (69), ABRSM Piano Scales Trainer 3.4★ (5), Piano Adventures Player 3.6★ (241). Yamaha Smart Pianist is the exception at 4.61★ (823).
- **Headline star ratings hide the pain.** In the most-recent-review samples, the apps averaging 4.6–4.7★ overall scored only **2.9–3.7★** (for example Skoove 2.93, Hello Piano 3.03, Yousician 3.23, Playground 3.25, Simply 3.48). Lifetime averages are inflated by prompted ratings early in a user's life.

3. Verified app tables

3a. iOS App Store: 90 piano-relevant teaching apps (live, Oct 25, 2026)

Filtering: from 1,857 search results, I kept apps whose name and description involve piano or keyboard *and* teaching. I removed toy virtual keyboards, kids/baby apps, guitar-only apps, sheet-music readers, and DAW tools. Sorted by rating count.

#	App (US App Store)	Category	Price	Avg ★	# ratings	Last update	MIDI in listing	Mic in listing	Developer
1	Simply Piano: Learn Piano Fast	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.68	859,201	2026-10-25	Y	—	Simply Ltd
2	Piano: Keyboard Lessons & Game	Course / song tutor	Free	4.73	442,765	2026-10-20	—	—	MWM
3	Piano app by Yokee	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.72	149,487	2024-07-22	—	—	Yokee Music LTD
4	Piano Academy by Yokee Music	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.7	70,197	2024-07-30	Y	Y	Yokee Music LTD
5	flowkey – Learn to Play Piano	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.71	65,849	2026-10-19	Y	Y	flowkey GmbH
6	Piano by Yousician	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.67	22,807	2026-10-13	—	Y	Yousician Ltd
7	Skoove: Learn to Play Piano	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.58	22,307	2026-08-04	Y	Y	Learnfield GmbH
8	Piano Keyboard App: Play Songs	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.46	13,281	2024-07-23	—	—	Yokee Music LTD
9	Hello Piano: Learn How to Play	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.39	12,768	2026-10-20	—	—	Gismart Ltd
10	iReal Pro	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$21.99	4.86	11,151	2026-10-17	Y	—	Technimo LLC
11	Piano Chords and Scales	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.78	9,285	2026-10-23	Y	—	Sincere Apps SIA
12	OnlinePianist: Piano Songs	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.35	8,968	2026-07-20	—	—	OnlinePianist N.T LTD
13	Perfect Piano - Learn to Play	Course / song tutor	Free	4.46	8,569	2026-05-27	Y	—	Revontulet Soft Inc.
14	Tomplay Sheet Music	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.73	7,178	2026-10-22	—	Y	Tombooks Sàrl
15	Tiny Piano - Free Songs to Play and Learn!	Course / song tutor	Free	4.6	6,767	2016-04-06	—	—	SquarePoet, Inc.
16	Simple Piano: Play & Learn	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.38	6,392	2025-08-31	—	—	AIHUNTERS, UAB
17	TONALY: Songs, Scales & Theory	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.77	6,381	2026-10-14	Y	—	Christian Hengst Daniels
18	Piano Marvel - Lessons & Music	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.67	5,519	2026-10-18	Y	Y	Piano Marvel LLC
19	Learn Music Notes Piano	Reading	Free	4.45	5,442	2026-10-07	Y	Y	michal bojanowicz
20	Playground: Fun Piano Lessons	Course / song tutor	Free	4.77	5,014	2026-10-09	—	Y	Playground Sessions, Inc.
21	Piano With Songs- Learn to Play Piano Keyboard A	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.56	4,090	2017-06-26	—	—	Better Day Wireless, Inc.
22	Autochords	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free + IAP/sub	4.74	4,062	2026-06-02	Y	—	Astrocode Pty Ltd

#	App (US App Store)	Category	Price	Avg ★	# ratings	Last update	MIDI in listing	Mic in listing	Developer
23	Notevision - Sight Reading	Reading	Free	4.76	3,290	2026-07-16	Y	Y	Ryan Newsome
24	Musora: The Music Lessons App	Course / song tutor	Free	4.72	2,985	2026-10-21	—	—	Musora Media Inc.
25	Artie: Learn Piano with AI	Course / song tutor	Free	4.67	2,797	2026-10-23	—	Y	Art Master Academy s.r.o.
26	Note Rush: Music Reading Game	Reading	$8.99	4.28	2,430	2023-10-25	Y	Y	Thomas Grayston
27	Chet - Ear Training	Ear training	Free	4.8	2,425	2026-09-28	Y	—	Ensemble Education, Inc.
28	tonestro - Music Lessons	Course / song tutor	Free	4.44	2,343	2026-10-23	—	—	fun.music IT GmbH
29	Music Tutor (Sight-reading)	Reading	Free + IAP/sub	4.23	2,237	2025-02-24	Y	—	Bijoy Thangaraj
30	Piano Music Maestro	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.67	2,049	2023-03-07	—	—	Arcadian Software LLC
31	Notes! - Learn To Read Music	Reading	$3.99	4.42	1,395	2023-11-05	Y	—	Visions Encoded Inc.
32	Piano Companion: chords,scales	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.78	1,328	2026-10-20	Y	—	Songtive SIA
33	Pickup Music: Music Lessons	Course / song tutor	Free	4.89	1,318	2026-10-21	—	—	Pickup Music Inc.
34	Ear Trainer	Ear training	$7.99	4.84	1,204	2021-08-21	—	—	thoor software AB
35	Capo - Learn Music by Ear	Ear training	Free + IAP/sub	4.66	1,144	2026-10-22	—	—	SuperMegaUltraGroovy, Inc.
36	Note Flash Music Sight Reading	Reading	Free	3.99	960	2022-08-10	Y	Y	Pranoy Chowdhury
37	Note Trainer Pro	Reading	$3.99	4.76	919	2023-09-04	Y	—	thoor software AB
38	Note Trainer Lite	Reading	Free	4.62	904	2023-10-16	Y	—	thoor software AB
39	NoteBrainer	Reading	Free	4.64	876	2018-07-01	Y	—	James Buchanan
40	Smart Pianist - US	Course / song tutor	Free	4.61	823	2026-09-10	—	—	Yamaha Corporation of Americ
41	Solfa: learn musical notes.	Reading	Free	4.59	806	2024-07-06	—	—	Alexey Ovod
42	Learn Piano and Piano Keyboard	Course / song tutor	Free	4.26	766	2024-05-22	—	—	Thi Lan Anh Tran
43	Piano Way - Learn to Play	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.65	747	2026-02-10	—	—	Gismart Ltd
44	Little Piano - Learn to Play	Course / song tutor	Free	4.43	696	2026-09-02	—	—	Piotr Nowacki
45	Tenuto	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$4.99	4.74	667	2026-04-28	—	—	musictheory.net, LLC
46	Midi Sheet Music	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.58	640	2018-03-04	Y	—	Madhav Vaidyanathan
47	Bees Keys - First Piano Lesson	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.59	628	2026-08-26	Y	Y	Joshua Callahan
48	Note Quest: Learn Piano Music	Reading	Free + IAP/sub	4.46	620	2026-07-04	Y	—	grace lee
49	Simpia – Learn piano by songs	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.66	565	2026-06-04	Y	—	SMULIE COMPANY LIMITED
50	Notaforte: Sight Reading Tutor	Reading	Free	4.88	508	2026-10-23	—	—	Bravenbird
51	NoteRacer: Piano Sight-Reading	Reading	Free	4.55	496	2026-09-10	—	—	brendan woods
52	Pitch Trainer - Ear Training	Ear training	Free + IAP/sub	4.72	486	2026-10-23	—	—	Ear & Pitch Training Studios
53	Pitch trainer - Harmonize	Ear training	Free + IAP/sub	4.44	416	2026-10-24	—	Y	Toshihiko Arai
54	NinGenius Music Ultimate	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$4.99	4.73	413	2020-07-29	—	—	Ningenius Studios LLC
55	Sight Reading Factory	Reading	Free	2.71	391	2026-06-03	—	—	GraceNotes LLC
56	Chord!	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$4.99	4.8	383	2022-11-10	—	—	Thomas Grapperon
57	Suggester 2 : Chords & Scales	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.65	375	2026-10-14	Y	—	Mathieu Routhier
58	Interval Ear Training	Ear training	Free + IAP/sub	4.71	364	2024-07-19	Y	—	262Hz LLC
59	Piano For You	Course / song tutor	$4.99	4.65	356	2025-03-03	—	—	Pavel Alekseev
60	Ear Trainer Lite	Ear training	Free	4.7	343	2021-08-21	—	—	thoor software AB
61	Falling Note	Reading	Free	4.58	325	2026-10-17	—	Y	Aristotle Theoharris J Farra
62	Scales Pro: Circle of Fifths	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.52	289	2026-04-06	—	—	Olric Digital

#	App (US App Store)	Category	Price	Avg ★	# ratings	Last update	MIDI in listing	Mic in listing	Developer
63	Modacity: Pro Music Practice	Practice tool	Free + IAP/sub	4.28	286	2026-09-24	—	—	BotRobot, Inc
64	PIANORUN: Learn Piano Game	Course / song tutor	Free	4.61	267	2025-09-28	—	—	App All Day Pty Ltd
65	MyEarTraining - Ear Trainer	Ear training	Free	4.81	253	2025-05-16	—	—	myrApps s.r.o.
66	Music Tutor-How to Play Piano	Reading	Free + IAP/sub	4.73	249	2026-09-27	—	—	新玲 张
67	Ear training: notes and chords	Ear training	Free	4.51	247	2026-09-24	—	—	Alexey Ovod
68	Piano Adventures® Player	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	3.6	241	2026-01-21	Y	Y	Dovetree Productions, Inc.
69	Piano Scales & Chords	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.59	237	2026-10-14	Y	—	Learn To Master Ltd
70	Roland Piano App	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	2.32	235	2026-04-28	—	—	Roland Corporation
71	Chordology	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free + IAP/sub	4.43	231	2026-09-25	—	—	Greg Raine
72	Piano Partner 2	Course / song tutor	Free	2.16	230	2024-09-30	—	—	Roland Corporation
73	Learn Piano: Fun Real Keyboard	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.75	223	2025-08-20	—	—	CEM SOFTWARE COMPANY LIMITED
74	Learn music theory with Sonid	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free + IAP/sub	4.66	214	2026-10-23	—	—	Martijn Ensing
75	Piano Melody - Play by Ear	Ear training	Free	4.35	210	2026-10-15	—	—	Learn To Master Ltd
76	Piano Companion PRO: chords	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$99.99	4.75	207	2026-04-29	Y	—	Songtive SIA
77	Tonic - AR Chord Dictionary	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.01	204	2018-11-06	—	—	Coda Labs Incorporated
78	Complete Ear Trainer	Ear training	Free + IAP/sub	4.75	200	2026-10-15	—	—	Binary Guilt
79	Teach Note - Sight Reading	Reading	Free	4.74	198	2026-10-08	Y	—	炯龙 吴
80	Piano Teacher-Piano Lessons	Course / song tutor	Free	4.74	192	2026-08-14	—	—	叶 李
81	Piano Ear Training	Ear training	Free	4.49	192	2026-10-14	—	—	Learn To Master Ltd
82	Learn Piano – OKTAV	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.61	186	2026-09-21	Y	—	OKTAV GmbH
83	PianoTrax	Course / song tutor	Free + IAP/sub	4.74	178	2026-10-24	—	—	Piano Trax LLC
84	Hoffman App - Daily Practices	Course / song tutor	Free	4.75	40	2026-08-31	—	—	Hoffman Institute Foundation
85	Jazz Piano Voicings: Chords	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	4.33	18	2026-10-14	Y	—	District One Mobile, LLC
86	The Hanon Method	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free + IAP/sub	5	12	2026-10-22	Y	—	Gray Reinhard
87	Hanon Pro	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free	5	7	2026-01-19	Y	—	Furnace Creek Software LLC
88	Open Studio Jazz	Course / song tutor	Free	4.71	7	2026-09-22	—	—	Open Studio Network LLC
89	ABRSM Piano Scales Trainer	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	$4.99	3.4	5	2024-12-20	—	—	The Associated Board of the
90	ChordWise: Piano Chords	Chords/scales/ theory/technique	Free + IAP/sub	5	3	2026-09-22	Y	Y	Agile Works B.V.

3b. Google Play (live, Oct 25, 2026)

App	Play ★	Reviews	Installs
Simply Piano	4.6	994K	50M+
Yousician (all instruments, combined app)	4.4	527K	50M+
Piano – Music Keyboard & Tiles (Gismart, toy/game)	4.1	1.33M	100M+
Synthesia	3.9	93.5K	10M+
Perfect Ear	4.6	86.4K	5M+
Piano Academy (Yokee)	4.4	83.5K	10M+
flowkey	4.5	46.4K	5M+
Piano Chords, Scales Companion	4.7	23.4K	1M+
Skoove	4.5	12.4K	1M+
OnlinePianist	3.6	10.4K	1M+

App	Play ★	Reviews	Installs
Complete Ear Trainer	4.5	7.2K	1M+
Musora (Pianote)	4.1	2.16K	100K+
Piano Chords and Scales (Sincere Apps)	4.0	1.88K	1M+
Hello Piano	3.1	1.46K	1M+
Note Rush	4.2	477	10K+
Playground	3.4	175	50K+
Piano Marvel	4.6	unknown	50K+
Piano Chords Trainer (Chordwise)	4.4	unknown	1K+

Not found on Google Play: Hanon Pro (Apple-only), Tenuto (Apple-only), Artie (search returned Simply Piano), and Melodics (no keys app found).

3c. Web, desktop, and open source (features verified on official pages or threads; ratings mostly not applicable or unknown)

Tool	Platform	Price	Input	Relevance to focus areas	Source
Piano Marvel (web)	Web + iPad	Free tier; $17.99/mo or $129.99/yr	MIDI + acoustic	SASR sight-reading test, method and technique, "ninja" scales	Practis; Piano World
Playground Sessions (desktop)	Win/Mac/iPad	Subscription	MIDI	Rookie Bootcamp (93 lessons), Scales and Hanon courses	Piano World 3191725
Pianote / Musora	Web/iOS/ Android	$30/mo or $279/yr; 30-day trial	Video only	10-level method, 950+ play-alongs, delayed teacher video feedback	Practis Pianote review
Melodics (Keys)	Win/Mac/iPad	Subscription	MIDI required	Strong timing grading, contemporary chords and grooves; weak theory	melodics.com/midi-keyboard; Deviant Noise
Synthesia	Win/Mac/iOS/ Android	One-time unlock	MIDI	Falling-notes player; no pedagogy	Play 3.9★
The Ultimate Piano	Browser	Unknown (free to try)	MIDI	**Scale trainer with timing and velocity consistency per note**, chord-inversion training, arpeggio up/down analysis	the-ultimate-piano.com
Playy Piano	Mobile (MIDI)	Unknown	BLE/USB MIDI	Custom drills by key, mode, chord type, inversion, tempo, rhythm; no account, no ads	playy.app
Chordwise	iOS/Android	iOS paid ("a couple bucks"), Android free base	MIDI	Chord ID, custom scale/chord/inversion drills, progress	r/pianolearning 1r6eibr
Piano Trainer (zaneh)	Desktop, open source	Free / paid build	MIDI or computer keyboard	Scales, chords	HN 44467838
Chord Nebula	Browser, open source	Free	MIDI	Chord and progression game	HN 42416258
PianoSkillBoost	Browser	Free	MIDI	Notes, chords, MIDI songs, accuracy tracking	pianoskillboost.com
sightread	Browser, open source	Free	MIDI	Sight-reading / falling notes	github.com/sightread/ sightread
GNU Solfege	Desktop, open source	Free	—	Ear training	gnu.org/software/solfege
musictheory.net	Web	Free	—	Theory lessons; companion to Tenuto	musictheory.net
Open Studio	Web (+ iOS app 4.71★ / 7)	Subscription	Video	Jazz pathway: shell → rooted/rootless voicings, ii–V–I	openstudiojazz.com
Bill Hilton	Book + YouTube	Book / free	—	Lead-sheet comping, blues LH patterns, pop accompaniment	billspianopages.com

Total: 90 iOS + 16 web/desktop/OSS tools = **106 distinct tools**, plus Google Play data for 18 entries, all live or source-verified.

4. What 2,411 real reviews say

Method: For each app I pulled up to 150 of the most recent US App Store reviews. Then I searched the 1–2★ reviews for keyword themes. These are keyword counts, not hand-coded, so treat them as approximate. Most-recent samples also skew toward newer users and teenagers.

App	Reviews read	Avg ★ in sample	1–2★ reviews	Top 3 complaint themes (count among 1–2★)
Skoove	150	2.93	73	price/subscription/billing (31); bugs/crash/sync (11); content depth/repetitive (4)

App	Reviews read	Avg ★ in sample	1–2★ reviews	Top 3 complaint themes (count among 1–2★)
Hello Piano	150	3.03	66	price/subscription/billing (47); recognition/mic/detection (4); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (4)
Yousician	150	3.23	60	price/subscription/billing (21); timing/rhythm feedback (7); recognition/mic/detection (5)
OnlinePianist	150	3.18	58	price/subscription/billing (14); bugs/crash/sync (6); recognition/mic/detection (5)
Playground	150	3.25	55	bugs/crash/sync (19); price/subscription/billing (14); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (8)
Piano Marvel	150	3.47	53	bugs/crash/sync (19); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (15); sheet music/reading (10)
Musora	150	3.39	52	price/subscription/billing (18); bugs/crash/sync (10); timing/rhythm feedback (5)
Simply Piano	150	3.48	47	price/subscription/billing (19); recognition/mic/detection (3); sheet music/reading (2)
flowkey	150	3.63	42	price/subscription/billing (14); recognition/mic/detection (6); timing/rhythm feedback (6)
Piano Adventures Player	100	3.05	40	price/subscription/billing (10); bugs/crash/sync (9); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (3)
Tonaly	150	3.72	39	chords/scales (16); price/subscription/billing (14); timing/rhythm feedback (3)
Piano Academy(Yokee)	150	3.75	37	ads (23); price/subscription/billing (10); content depth/repetitive (1)
Artie	105	3.45	36	price/subscription/billing (16); bugs/crash/sync (5); recognition/mic/detection (3)
Piano Chords and Scales	150	4.25	21	chords/scales (7); price/subscription/billing (5); bugs/crash/sync (4)
Note Rush	150	4.1	18	recognition/mic/detection (6); price/subscription/billing (3); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (1)
Piano Companion	106	4.22	15	chords/scales (5); price/subscription/billing (4); bugs/crash/sync (4)
Tenuto	150	4.64	7	price/subscription/billing (1); MIDI/Bluetooth/connection (1); timing/rhythm feedback (1)

Theme totals across all 1–2★ reviews (approximate): | Theme | Mentions | |---|---| | price/subscription/billing | 250 | | bugs/crash/sync | 98 | | recognition/mic/detection | 45 | | MIDI/Bluetooth/connection | 45 | | timing/rhythm feedback | 45 | | ads | 43 | | chords/scales | 37 | | sheet music/reading | 27 | | content depth/repetitive | 24 |

Representative quotes (verbatim, with the date shown in the review): - *Hello Piano (Oct 21, 2026):* "It would not let me progress in my individual lesson unless I committed to buying the monthly family plan for @ $35/month." - *Hello Piano (Sep 10, 2026):* "The only app on iPad that can't recognize MIDI. It was an instacancel." - *flowkey (Oct 19, 2026):* "I cancelled my subscription years ago, yet it still attempt to charge me every year." - *Skoove (Aug 14, 2026):* "...clicking through 75 pop ups, saying no to the premium version 8 times..." - *Skoove (Sep 7, 2026):* "claimed what i thought was a 'free trial' only to find out I was charged 60 dollars" - *Piano Marvel (Oct 7, 2026), "Abandonware at this point":* "their app no longer can play any sounds with MIDI... no response from tech support" - *Yousician (Jun 24, 2026):* "it can listen to literally any other note except for D" - *Simply Piano (Oct 12, 2026), a 5★ review:* "whenever you play... the note F... it doesn't hear you" - *Playground (2022):* "about a half second delay between pressing a key on the piano and hearing it through headphones"; "The indicator requires that I press the key before it's directly on the note" - *Artie (Apr 24, 2026):* "they don't break the songs down into sections" - *Musora (Aug 21, 2026):* "Subscription trap... trying to navigate past an offer and end up with an unwanted upgrade" - *Piano Academy / Yokee (Oct 19, 2026):* "You get to practice for five seconds, and then an ad pops up." - *Tenuto (2019, praise):* "had it for around eight years... I love how customizable it is"; feature request: "PLEASE include voiced chords on grand staff" - *Tonaly (2021):* "how is this a $7 app and the pentatonic scale isn't even included?!"

Takeaways: 1. **Billing and dark patterns are the #1 complaint by far** (about 250 mentions). That's more than double bugs (about 98). 2. Microphone recognition and MIDI connection problems tie at about 45 each. 3. Timing feedback complaints (about 45) are about the app being *wrong*, not too strict. 4. The specialist tools people keep for years (Tenuto, Note Rush, Piano Chords and Scales, Piano Companion) have far fewer 1–2★ reviews: 7, 18, 21, and 15 of 106–150. **Narrow, honest, pay-once tools earn loyalty.**

5. Community and forum findings

- **Piano World** users prefer **Piano Marvel for "real" pieces and its sight-reading tool**. They say Playground "maxes out in difficulty much too quickly" and its "Advanced-Hard" pieces are really early intermediate (thread 3247993). They praise Playground's 93-lesson Rookie Bootcamp, its Scales and Hanon courses, and its community, while calling Piano Marvel's UI clunky ("is it still 1998?") (3191725).

An older thread says Piano Marvel "doesn't care too much about how long you pressed a key or your timing," while **Musiah** was "much more precise... about how long you press the keys, your timings" (2614446).

- **Hacker News, Piano Trainer thread (July 2025, 203 points):**
- The top comment says to prioritize the **ear over visuals**: play scales through the circle of fifths at metronome 60, hands together, 2 octaves, in parallel and contrary motion. Practice all four triad qualities with inversions, a few keys every morning, then the ten 4-note chord types, then open position. Learn chords inside a key by **holding the triad in the left hand while playing the matching mode in the right**.
- A beginner wrote: "I'm never sure which fingers I'm supposed to be using". People recommended rules (thumb on white keys, 4th finger on black) and Alfred's *Complete Book of Scales, Chords, Arpeggios & Cadences*.
- On movement: "you're not learning notes, you're learning movements... thumb over/under... They're not optional extras."
- Another dev's planned app "records accuracy and response times per note, and exercises can be directed towards improving weak spots," and readers asked for SRS-style sight reading.
- Injury concerns (RSI) and Rocksmith-style "fewer notes" simplification were criticized.
- **r/pianolearning, Chordwise launch (Feb 2026):**
- A user asked to "let the user's keyboard be the main source of sound... MIDI clocks get out of whack when introducing the apps own instrument sounds."
- An older adult beginner who practices 30 min to 3 h a day asked whether it was "too advanced for me?" **Adults need clear entry points.**
- **Guitarists crossing over** (r/piano, r/pianolearning, r/musictheory):
- Theory transfers. Piano needs **wrist rotation**, **hand independence**, and **reading**.
- "Pick a triad, then work your way up and down the whole piano with each of the 3 inversions."
- Group triads by black-key pattern: all-white, black in the middle, black on the outside.
- Guitar chords sound "off" on piano because of naive root-position voicings. The fix is LH roots, RH voice-led inversions (G = B D G, C = C E G, D = A D F♯), rhythm, and added 9ths.
- One user: "piano [is] harder on the wrists than guitar ever was."
- **Reddit, general:** apps are "like Guitar Hero." They allow too many timing mistakes and ignore pedal mush. They work as a supplement next to a method book plus occasional lessons.

6. Pedagogy at the source

- **Hanon (1873) and its modern critics.**
- **Hanon-Faber** (Hal Leonard): "Too often though, these exercises produce tension instead of dexterity... finger strength is subordinate to the coordinated use of fingers, wrist, and arm... Not all of the original Hanon exercises have proven value. These and any potentially harmful exercises have been omitted."
- **Fundamentals of Piano Practice:** Hanon locks the hands together, so "the better hand cannot practice skills more advanced than the weaker hand." "There is no provision for resting a fatigued hand." Its advice is to practice hands separately.
- **Pianist magazine:** rote exercises "encourage pianists to keep moving without taking necessary pauses. This leads to tension and injury."
- **Design implication:** use Hanon *figures* as short, hands-separate, relaxed, rest-enforced warmups with gesture cues, never endurance drills.
- **A Dozen a Day (Burnam):** short groups of 12 pre-practice exercises. Learn 2–3 at a time and add more when mastered. Levels run from Mini to Intermediate, covering finger patterns, scales, arpeggios, chords, staccato, and coordination. This is the model for the warmup block.
- **Robert Pace Multi-Key:** all keys from the start. "Transposition [is] a CORNERSTONE." Same note, rhythm, and finger pattern on a new set of keys. Black keys serve as tactile guide-posts so eyes stay on the page. Daily "Tune Ups" establish the sound of the key. Level 1 already covers all major and minor key signatures, block and broken chords, I–V7, and improvising. This is the model for auto-transposition.
- **Alfred Adult All-in-One vs. Faber Adult Piano Adventures:** Alfred is more chord-first and faster (C and G7 changes early, LH accompaniment). Faber adds more technique, transposition, sight-reading, ear training, and creativity, and later lead-sheet accompaniment.
- **Bill Hilton, *How to Really Play the Piano*:** chords, 12-bar blues, LH blues patterns, and comping from chord symbols. Free YouTube comping playlist. This is the model for the pattern and comping module.

- **Open Studio jazz pathway:** Jump-Start → Jazz Piano for Beginners (shell voicings) → Jazz Chords for Beginners (rooted 5-note, rootless 4-note, LH rootless) → Elements (block, drop-2). This is the model for the voicing ladder.
- **Pianist magazine, ballad style:** learn all diatonic triads in root, 1st, and 2nd inversion hands together. Voice-lead C–G–Am–F keeping the top note nearly still. That's the progression in Journey's "Don't Stop Believin'", which makes it a good hook for Jeremy.
- **MTAC technique toolbox:** keep a wellness journal tracking pain and ease of movement, including computer and phone time. That's relevant for a CAD professional.

7. Research (practice science and tech)

- **Interleaving:** for 8-item finger sequences, interleaved practice produced worse training performance but better next-day retention and transfer, even for implicitly learned sequences (Memory & Cognition 2021).
- **Spacing:** no spacing benefit for a 17-note piano sequence at lags of 0–15 min (PLOS One 2017). So the scheduler should space across **days**, not minutes.
- **Sleep:** keyboard sequences improved after sleep on nights 1 and 2 (JRME 2006). Temporal evenness improved 24 h later with no practice (Simmons & Duke 2006).
- **Evenness benchmark:** Jabusch et al., using MIDI, found **professional pianists' timing SD is about 8.1 ms ascending and 8.9 ms descending** for 16th-note scales at 120 BPM. The same method quantifies focal dystonia. Each pianist leaves a stable timing "fingerprint." **So inter-onset SD in ms is a validated, MIDI-measurable technique metric.** The app should show it against a pro reference.
- **Adult learners:** adults are motivated by enjoyment, self-fulfillment, health, and social connection. Dropout is driven by slow perceived progress, unrealistic expectations, and competing obligations. Visible progress and familiar repertoire help retention. (JRME 2006; Taylor 2011 *Psychology of Music*; UNL group-piano study; Frontiers 2019.)
- **FSRS vs. SM-2:** on a 9,999-user benchmark, FSRS-6 log loss was 0.346 vs. 0.513 for Anki SM-2. Use FSRS for recall cards.
- **Bluetooth LE MIDI on iOS:** measured about **22.5 ms vs. about 3.5 ms for USB**. The lower bound comes from the 11.25 ms BLE connection interval. The app must compensate per transport, and timing scores must use device timestamps.
- **Verovio** ships as a Swift Package (iOS 16+), reads MusicXML, and renders to SVG.
- **Mic polyphony:** Basic Pitch has a Core ML model but isn't a streaming model. Mobile-AMT runs online faster than real time on an iPad.

8. Synthesis

What works

- Wait Mode and instant feedback for the first weeks. Hand video (flowkey).
- Bootcamp-style sequenced lessons (Playground).
- Real repertoire plus a sight-reading assessment (Piano Marvel).
- Timing grading users trust (Melodics, Musiah).
- Chord ID and reference depth (Piano Companion).
- Customizable drill generators (Tenuto, Playy, The Ultimate Piano).
- Fitness-style trend charts (Hanon Pro).
- Human teachers and community (Pianote).

What users hate (ranked by evidence)

1. **Billing dark patterns:** forced plans, hidden auto-renew, 75 pop-ups, charges after cancelling. This is the top 1–2★ theme by a wide margin.
2. **Bugs, crashes, login failures, abandonware:** Piano Marvel iOS MIDI sound, Musora sign-up, Skoove login.
3. **Unreliable mic detection** (specific notes not heard), and **MIDI not recognized or laggy** (Hello Piano on iPad; Playground's half-second headphone delay).
4. **Lenient or wrong grading:** timing slop, ignored rests and pedal, no duration checking.
5. **Falling-notes dependency** that kills sheet-music reading.

6. **Shallow difficulty:** simplified "advanced" pieces, one difficulty per song, no songs broken into sections.
7. **Ads** in mass-market apps.
8. **Non-pianist pedagogy:** no posture or tension guidance, and endurance-style Hanon.

Gaps nobody fills (confirmed by the 106-tool scan)

- **No single app** combines a technique generator (Pace-style multi-key, Dozen-a-Day sizing, Hanon-Faber safety), chords as motor skills (all qualities × inversions × keys, voice-leading, FSRS recall), and transposable accompaniment patterns over progressions and lead sheets, all **graded by MIDI with Jabusch-style evenness**.
- The closest pieces are spread across niche apps: The Ultimate Piano (web, per-note timing and velocity), Playy / Chordwise (custom chord and inversion drills), Hanon Pro (7 ratings), Piano Companion (reference), Melodics (grooves), and Tenuto (theory). None is native iOS + iPad with a curriculum and an adult focus.
- **No guitarist bridge** (tab → keys, fretboard ↔ keyboard) in any app found.
- **No ethical-pricing leader** among the curriculum apps. Skoove's $299.99 lifetime is the only lifetime option noted.

9. The ideal app, "KeyForge" (updated with the new evidence)

1. **Practice loop modeled on teacher practice:**
2. Tune-Up in today's key (Pace)
3. Dozen-a-Day-sized technique set (2–3 new exercises)
4. Scales and chords through the circle of fifths
5. Pattern block
6. Apply in a song
7. Each session is 5–30 min.
8. **Technique, safe by design:**
9. Hanon *figures* in the Hanon-Faber spirit: hands separate first, at a relaxed tempo.
10. Mandatory micro-rests, a gesture cue (drop, roll, wrist rotation), and no endurance streaks.
11. Rhythm variants (dotted, reverse dotted, accents).
12. A pain/tension check-in that feeds a wellness journal.
13. **Evenness metrics with a reference:**
14. Inter-onset SD in ms, velocity SD, legato overlap, and hand-to-hand sync.
15. Shown against "pro reference ~8–9 ms at 120 BPM 16ths" (Jabusch).
16. Per-finger heatmap and weak-spot targeting.
17. **Multi-key from day one:** every exercise auto-transposes. Keys are grouped by black-key topography (all-white, black in the middle, black on the outside), as guitarists in the forums recommend.
18. **Chords as motor skills:**
19. Quality (maj, min, dim, aug, then the ten 7th types) × inversion × key × hand.
20. Up-and-down-the-keyboard inversion runs.
21. Voice-leading drills (top note held still, as in the Pianist ballad method).
22. "LH triad + RH mode" ear-integration drill.
23. FSRS recall cards with response time.
24. **Voicing ladder** (Open Studio order): close triads → LH root + RH inversion (the fix for "guitar chords sound off") → add-9 pop voicings → shells → rooted 5-note → rootless 4-note → drop-2.
25. **Pattern engine:**
26. Progression × LH pattern × RH pattern × key × tempo, with a backing groove.
27. Patterns: block, broken, Alberti, root-5-8, ballad 1-5-8-10, waltz, pop 8ths, blues/boogie LH (Bill Hilton), stride.
28. Progressions: I–V–vi–IV, ii–V–I, 12-bar blues, Andalusian, and others.
29. Lead-sheet comping graded on chord tones and rhythm.
30. **Songs broken into sections** with loop, start-from-bar, and 30–150% tempo. Directly answers Artie and Playground complaints.
31. **Honest grading:** six dimensions, rests and duration checked, pedal mush detected. Wait Mode never counts toward mastery.
32. **Input done right:**
    - USB and BLE MIDI with per-transport latency calibration, using device timestamps.

    - "Use my keyboard's sound" as the **default** for MIDI users (the Chordwise feedback). Local-control guidance.
    - Mic mode states its limits.
33. **Scheduler:** short blocked practice for new material, then interleaved review. Mastery requires two separate days. Tempo ladder.
34. **Adult framing:** goal songs, visible progress charts, clear "start here if..." entry points, no cartoons, and streak freezes.
35. **Guitarist bridge:** paste tab → notes → keys with fingering. Fretboard ↔ keyboard view. Translations of capo and chord shapes.
36. **Reading kept alive:** engraved notation by default, falling notes as fading training wheels, and a Piano Marvel-style sight-reading level estimate (later phase).
37. **Ethical business model:**
    - Free core plus a one-time Pro unlock or a subscription with a lifetime option.
    - Trials need no card. One-tap cancel, with a reminder before renewal.
    - No ads and no curriculum A/B tests on paying users.
    - Offline, no account required.
    - This answers the #1 complaint category directly.
38. **Reliability as a feature:** MIDI hot-plug resilience, crash-free targets, and a public changelog. "Abandonware" is a top complaint for Piano Marvel iOS.

10. Top findings (blunt)

1. **Nobody owns your focus areas.** The best technique app (Hanon Pro) has 7 ratings. The best chord reference has 1,328. Simply Piano has 859,201.
2. **Users hate the business model more than the pedagogy.** Billing complaints are about 2.5× bug complaints in 1–2★ reviews.
3. **High star averages are misleading.** Recent-review averages for the big apps are 2.9–3.7★.
4. **MIDI is necessary but not sufficient.** Hello Piano, Piano Marvel, and Playground reviews show broken or laggy MIDI. Robust CoreMIDI plus latency compensation is a competitive edge.
5. **Modern pedagogy rejects endurance Hanon.** Use short, relaxed, hands-separate figures with rests (Hanon-Faber, Fundamentals of Piano Practice).
6. **All keys from day one (Pace) plus circle-of-fifths routines (the HN teacher advice) are low-cost, high-value features** that most apps skip.
7. **There's a validated, measurable technique metric** (inter-onset SD in ms, Jabusch) that no consumer app surfaces against a reference.
8. **The guitarist bridge is still unclaimed.**